



Divya Deshmukh wins World Junior Chess title



Divya Deshmukh added another significant title to her already impressive collection, recently. The 18-year-old from Nagpur won the World junior girls' chess championship after beating Bulgaria's Beloslava Krasteva in the final round at the Gift City Club.

The top-seeded Divya finished with 10 points, out of a possible 11, as she remained unbeaten, winning nine games and drawing two. The title in the open section was claimed by Kazakhstan's Kazybek Nogerbek, whose win in the last round against the sole overnight leader Mamikon Gharibyan of Armenia took him to 8.5 points.

Armenia's Emin Ohanyan had already scored 8.5 points, thanks to his victory against Daniel Quizon of the Philippines. A better tie-break score gave the title to Nogerbek, seeded ninth.

Luka Budisavljevic of Serbia finished third. Pranav Anand, who began as the third seed, was the best-placed Indian at 10th.

In the girls' section, Mariam Mkrtchyan took the runner-up spot after finishing half a point behind Divya. Azerbaijan's Ayan Allahverdiyeva was third.

P. K. AJITH KUMAR

» INDIAN PLAYGROUND

SPORTOON



1 Neeru Pathak broke the girls' 400m under-18 National record of former Asian junior champion Rezoana Mallick Heena while winning the gold at the 19th National youth athletics championships in Bilaspur, on June 16. The 17-year-old from Delhi clocked 52.85s (old National youth record 52.98s) and also qualified for the under-20 Worlds (entry standard 55.40s) which will be held in Lima, Peru, in August. Punjab's Mannat Brar, the silver medallist (55.84), finished three seconds behind Neeru.

STAN RAYAN

2 Kerala's unseeded Karan Thapa defeated Karnataka's third-seeded Kevin Titus Suresh 6-4, 6-4 and won the boys singles title in the AITA National Series under-18 tennis tournament in Bengaluru. Elsewhere, Riya Sachdeva saved two match points to beat top seed Aditi Rawat 2-6, 7-5, 6-4 in the final of the Rs.100,000 AITA women's tennis tournament at the Faridabad Tennis Academy. In the semifinals, the 17-year-old Riya had beaten Yashika Shokeen, a member of the Indian junior Billie Jean King Cup team. It was the third singles title in the women's circuit for Riya.

TEAM SPORTSTAR